

Ablation studies

Project: Reproducible AI Research Study

1. Your mission

Your learning target

I can explain the mechanism and terminology of ablation studies.

I can apply the stated procedure to a new case with a traceable result.

I can identify an assumption or limitation and design a revealing follow-up.

Remember before reading

Close your notes first. A rough first answer helps us choose the right starting point; it is not a score for your ability.

Without opening the old lesson, explain one key idea from Multiple comparisons. Give an example and a mistake that the idea helps you avoid.

Without opening the old lesson, explain one key idea from Effect size and practical importance. Give an example and a mistake that the idea helps you avoid.

Without opening the old lesson, explain one key idea from Confounders and controls. Give an example and a mistake that the idea helps you avoid.

After trying, check the relevant lesson or ask your teacher. Change the part of your explanation that the evidence shows was wrong.

This week you will practise:

Explain the mechanism and terminology of ablation studies

Apply the stated procedure to a new case with a traceable result

Identify an assumption or limitation and design a revealing follow-up

Retrieve what you already know

Recall Multiple comparisons. Explain why a recorded result needs its input conditions and evidence source before it can support a claim.

My starting explanation

This week's end goal

Explain ablation studies using the records and boundaries of this fictional investigation.

2. Notice the evidence

Ablation removes a component to investigate its contribution under a controlled comparison. Interactions can make contributions depend on other components.

Begin by writing the question the procedure is intended to answer. Identify the information already supplied, the information it will produce and the information still missing. These are constructed classroom examples; they do not require live accounts, private records or an external service. Do not treat a plausible explanation as a measured outcome.

List the given facts and one fact that is not supplied.

3. See how it works

Compare full system, without retrieval and without validation on identical cases and scoring. Hold other settings fixed; record changed failure categories, not just totals.

Ablation studies — evidence trace

Input and scope · Check or calculation · Conclusion and limit

Input and scope: Full system8/10, without retrieval5/10, without validation7/10; the last permits an unauthorised action.

Check or calculation: Compare full system, without retrieval and without validation on identical cases and scoring. Hold other settings fixed; record changed failure categories, not just totals.

Conclusion and limit: Drops3 and1 passes respectively in this sample. Validation's critical action boundary is not captured by pass-count magnitude alone.

The figure connects this chapter's worked input, declared procedure and result. Read the complete worked reasoning for qualifiers and intermediate steps; the abbreviated labels do not replace that reasoning.

Before applying the procedure, write its units, denominator or decision boundary where relevant. A partner should be able to repeat each step using the same inputs. If a required input is absent or violates the stated contract, record that condition explicitly instead of quietly replacing it with a convenient value.

Connect the picture and the explanation

Point to the input, the deciding step and the result in this week's visual. Explain the same step in ordinary words. A picture helps when you can say what each part represents.

4. Compare the cases

Compare a familiar case with a changed case

Full system8/10, without retrieval5/10, without validation7/10; the last permits an unauthorised action. Show the intermediate steps and give the conclusion with its scope.

Keep the procedure fixed. Explain what changed in the inputs and result.

Change one thing in the pictured case

Change: Remove the filter and also change the model version.

Prediction: The comparison no longer isolates the filter.

Reason: Two simultaneous changes provide alternative explanations.

5. Words that unlock the idea

Word · Meaning

Word: Ablation

Meaning: Removing or disabling a component in a comparison

Word: Conditional contribution

Meaning: An effect given the other components

Word: Interaction

Meaning: An effect depending on another factor's setting

Use two terms to explain a step in this week's example.

6. Follow a worked example

Full system 8/10, without retrieval 5/10, without validation 7/10; the last permits an unauthorised action.

Drops 3 and 1 passes respectively in this sample. Validation's critical action boundary is not captured by pass-count magnitude alone.

Compare the intermediate evidence with the final statement. Explain why each number or decision follows from the stated inputs. The conclusion belongs to this scenario and procedure; changing the inputs, evaluation population or authority can change what it establishes. Retain the raw record so a later revision can be compared honestly.

Learn from the worked case

Cover the result before checking it. Say what is given, choose the procedure, and follow one step at a time. Then uncover the result and explain your first mismatch. Ask why a step is allowed, not only what number it produces.

A pictorial worked case: Ablation studies

Remove one component at a time. A retrieval pipeline has search plus a relevance filter. A team tests the filter's contribution.

The facts we will use

Full pipeline: 8/10 correct. Filter removed: 6/10 on the same cases, with all other settings fixed.

Relevance-filter ablation

correct answers out of 10 shared cases

Full pipeline



Filter removed



Bar length shows the supplied value; the marked baseline is zero.

Ablation studies

Start with the supplied facts

Follow each arrow. Ask which fact allows the next step.



1. Name the component

The relevance filter is the single declared change.



2. Run the ablation

Remove only the filter and preserve cases and scoring.



3. Compare outcomes

Correctness falls from 80% to 60%, two cases in this set.

CHANGE ONE THING

Remove the filter and also change the model version.

Explain the changed result using the matching lesson.

Read the picture one step at a time

Step · What happens and why

Step: 1. Name the component

What happens and why: The relevance filter is the single declared change.

Step: 2. Run the ablation

What happens and why: Remove only the filter and preserve cases and scoring.

Step: 3. Compare outcomes

What happens and why: Correctness falls from 80% to 60%, two cases in this set.

Match each pictured step to the supplied facts. This is a worked teaching case, not an independent assessment.

Why this result follows

An ablation probes a component by removing or changing it while holding the rest fixed. It supports a scoped comparison, not a claim that the component always helps.

What this example does not establish

Interactions and small-sample variability remain; this illustrative difference is not a universal causal estimate.

7. Find and repair a mistake

Removing a component changes a complete procedure; attribution depends on the controlled design and possible interactions.

A useful check asks what would make the reasoning fail. Distinguish a failure to execute the declared procedure from a weakness in the procedure itself. The first may require a correction; the second requires an explicitly revised method and new evidence. Preserve unsuccessful cases so an improved result cannot hide the original problem.

Guided: restate the worked result, then name the assumption or limitation that prevents a broader conclusion.

Locate the earliest unsupported step

A report omits this qualification: Removing a component changes a complete procedure; attribution depends on the controlled design and possible interactions. Explain how omitting it could change a reader's interpretation, and write an accurate replacement.

State one repair and the checks you would rerun.

8. Practise together

Explain the weekly mechanism in your own words. Use the worked scenario to name its input, decision rule and output.

Guided: restate the worked result, then name the assumption or limitation that prevents a broader conclusion.

Explain your prediction to a partner before comparing results.

Practise with less help: Trace the worked case

Use workbook W2 for the connected example “Ablation studies”. First fill the input and rule boxes. Try the middle steps before asking for a hint. After a hint, try the next step yourself.

Plan · Do · Check

Plan: What is given? Which rule or procedure applies?

Do: Record each intermediate step.

Check: Does the result follow? What remains unknown?

Explain your trace to a partner. Your partner points to one step to check. Swap roles on the next case. Each person writes their own explanation.

Check your reasoning

Use the worked case for Ablation studies. Proposed explanation: “The worked result establishes every future case”. Decide whether this explanation is supported. Point to the step or supplied fact that decides; explain your repair if needed.

Answer on your own before discussion. If you are unsure, say which step you need help with.

Explain the picture

Calculate the filter ablation’s two rates and count change. Which single component is altered, and why does also changing the model prevent isolating the filter?

My explanation using a pictured step and the given facts

This is supported practice. Keep the separately named independent case for an attempt before feedback.

9. Run the investigation

Predict, investigate and preserve the evidence

Full system 8/10, without retrieval 5/10, without validation 7/10; the last permits an unauthorised action. Show the intermediate steps and give the conclusion with its scope.

Record · Your evidence

Record: Given input and fixed rule

Your evidence: _____

Record: Prediction before checking

Your evidence: _____

Record: Actual result, or “not run”

Your evidence: _____

Record: First mismatch and one explanation

Your evidence: _____

Record: Boundary or missing input and expected response

Your evidence: _____

On paper, trace the supplied procedure. If code is provided, predict before running it in a local practice file. Never write an expected answer as though it were an observed run.

Plan → try → check

Before trying: what do I expect, and why? While trying: which step could first go wrong? Afterwards: what did I actually observe, and what should change? Keep “not run” if you only traced the procedure.

10. Build your understanding

Explain → apply → challenge

Explain the weekly mechanism in your own words. Use the worked scenario to name its input, decision rule and output.

A report omits this qualification: Removing a component changes a complete procedure; attribution depends on the controlled design and possible interactions. Explain how omitting it could change a reader's interpretation, and write an accurate replacement.

For the worked scenario, propose one additional case that could reveal a failure, describe its expected outcome before running it, and explain what would need to remain fixed for a fair comparison. Do not reuse W4 as a new final test after receiving feedback.

Explain which evidence supports your conclusion and which claim remains unproved.

11. Connect your project

Add a labelled ablation studies evidence sheet to Reproducible AI Research Study. Show how you can explain the mechanism and terminology of ablation studies. Use the supplied fictional case and keep its inputs, intermediate steps, calculation or prediction, and limitation. Connect this record to last week's record; a matching answer without a trace is insufficient.

Project evidence · Record

Project evidence: Component and version

Record: _____

Project evidence: Inputs permitted at prediction time

Record: _____

Project evidence: Trace and comparison with earlier work

Record: _____

Project evidence: Failure, limit and human review

Record: _____

Evidence for your project

For the Reproducible AI Research Study, retain an annotated worked trace and the changed-case reasoning. Connect the claim to its records, units and assumptions so another investigator can challenge or reproduce it.

12. Show what you know

Complete the supported workbook tasks before attempting W4 independently. Record any hints or help used. After feedback, use the teacher's fresh retry rather than copying the earlier answer. For a project, select a relevant new case, predict the outcome from the declared rule and preserve the result alongside any revision.

Exit: propose one revealing change to the worked scenario. State the expected outcome and the evidence that would make you revise your explanation.

For the worked scenario, propose one additional case that could reveal a failure, describe its expected outcome before running it, and explain what would need to remain fixed for a fair comparison. Do not reuse W4 as a new final test after receiving feedback.

My limited claim and a useful next check

13. Study a complete case

Complete evidence record

Ablation studies — evidence trace

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Conclusion and limit: Drops3 and1 passes respectively in this sample. Validation's critical action boundary is not captured by pass-count magnitude alone.

The figure connects this chapter's worked input, declared procedure and result. Read the complete worked reasoning for qualifiers and intermediate steps; the abbreviated labels do not replace that reasoning.

Follow the input through the stated procedure to its result. Cover the result first, predict it, then explain every intermediate step. The text/table accompanies the figure so the example can be read without colour.

My complete trace of the worked case

14. Try a new case independently

Independent case: Apply a new case independently

Full12/15, without A9/15, without B11/15. Compute sample drops and state interaction limit.

My independent explanation, trace and limits

Attempt this case before feedback. Record any help. Earlier examples below are further practice; a case already practised with feedback cannot establish fresh transfer.

Attempt this without hints

Full12/15, without A9/15, without B11/15. Compute sample drops and state interaction limit.

My independent procedure, result and limitation

Record support used: none, hint or teacher explanation. After feedback, a different case is needed to demonstrate independence.

Use feedback to improve

Attempt the independent case before hints. Record whether you worked alone, used a hint or followed a model. After feedback, fix the first unsupported step and explain why it changed. A later check uses a changed case, not a copied answer.